

PROGRESSION TOOL

THE FLARE SIMULATION & STEP-DOWN DRILL SHEET

Safely Return to Activity After a Flare

CHASE THE DATA, NOT THE SENSATION.

The Flare Recovery Playbook | Dr. Jonathan Schutza, PT, DPT

Step-Down Progression Protocol

Gradually return to normal activity levels

Before Starting

- ⚠ Pain must be stable for 48 hours before progressing
- ⚠ Morning pain should be $\leq 3/10$
- ⚠ No increase in swelling or redness
- ⚠ You can walk 10 minutes without pain increase

Stage 1: Minimal Load (Days 1-3)

Goal: Pain-free movement patterns

Walking: 5-10 min, 2-3x/day | Avoid: Hills, uneven terrain, barefoot

MAX PAIN ALLOWED (0-10)

DAILY STEP LIMIT

Stage 2: Light Load (Days 4-7)

Goal: Build tolerance

Walking: 15-20 min, 2-3x/day | Add: Gentle calf raises, ankle mobility

MAX PAIN ALLOWED (0-10)

DAILY STEP LIMIT

Stage 3: Moderate Load (Week 2)

Goal: Increase capacity

Walking: 30 min continuous | Add: Gentle hills, stairs as tolerated

MAX PAIN ALLOWED (0-10)

DAILY STEP GOAL

Stage 4: Return to Normal (Week 3+)

Goal: Full activity

Walking: Normal daily amounts | Add: Running/jumping if previously active

TARGET ACTIVITY LEVEL

PAIN THRESHOLD (0-10)

Daily Progress Log

Track your step-down progression

Date	Stage	Morning Pain	Activity	Duration	Evening Pain	Notes

What I Learned From This Flare

Prevention Strategies for Next Time